

Global Cinematic Cities

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NEW LANDSCAPES OF FILM AND MEDIA

EDITED BY

Johan Andersson and Lawrence Webb



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INTRODUCTION: DECENTRING THE CINEMATIC CITY – FILM AND MEDIA IN THE DIGITAL AGE

JOHAN ANDERSSON AND LAWRENCE WEBB

Over the past twenty years, the relationship between screen media and urban space has become one of the most productive interdisciplinary areas of enquiry across a broad intersection of fields, from film and media studies to geography, architecture and visual culture.¹ For film studies, this spatial turn has helped to remap the discipline at different scales, locating film texts, industries and cultures in specific local geographies, while simultaneously reframing and decentering the traditional category of national cinema within global networks of transnational flows. At the same time, urban studies and related disciplines have been refreshed by a new emphasis on the role of audiovisual media in the production of space and the cultural dynamism of urban economies. Yet, somewhat paradoxically, this academic discourse of cinema and the city has flourished at a moment when its key terms have become inherently unstable. Tectonic shifts driven by globalisation and digital technologies have led scholars in both film studies and urban studies to challenge the foundations of their traditional objects of study. As the analytic focus of film studies is questioned by the proliferation of digital media, so the traditional concept of the city is destabilised by rapid urbanisation at a global scale. This collection explores the evolving, mutually constitutive relations between moving image media and the global city, but it does so at a time when profound questions are being asked about the ontological and experiential nature of each. What is cinema and what is a city in the twenty-first century? And how are these categories intertwined in an urban environment increasingly dominated by screens and portable devices beyond the traditional movie theatre?

For film scholars, the shift from celluloid to digital and the perceived displacement of theatrical exhibition by a variety of media platforms has led to a renewed

scrutiny of the material basis of film, the specificity of the cinema experience, and by extension, the aims, boundaries and practices of film studies as a discipline. A good deal of scholarship has been preoccupied with the impact of the digital turn, which has brought far-reaching changes to production, distribution, exhibition and promotion, while also disrupting and reorganising traditional forms of audience engagement and interaction. In the first instance, the rapid move to digital production has led theorists to revise our understanding of the medium's relationship to the material world (see Rodowick 2007), while others have investigated the shifting interface between audience and image. Francesco Casetti (2013), for example, argues that the culture of the screen, with its familiar metaphors of window, frame and mirror, has been superseded by that of the display, the emblematic device at the centre of a new media landscape with distinctive modes of interactivity, attention and sociality. Likewise, Steven Shaviro has argued that film has given way to an emerging 'media regime' characterised by digital technologies and a corresponding structure of feeling he calls 'post-cinematic affect' (2010: 1). Though the extent of these transformations might be challenged, they nevertheless present vital questions about the spatial relationships between image and environment, viewer and screen.

For urban scholars, the unprecedented speed of urbanisation in the global South has challenged many preconceptions about urban development, while the intertwined character of physical and digital space has transformed labour markets and the social life of cities. Contrary to the 'death of distance' predictions of twenty years ago, the digital revolution – in tandem with sustainability agendas that have revalorised the concept of dense urban living – have contributed to the continued concentration of the world's population in cities rather than their anticipated dispersal. In this context of urban growth, the headline-grabbing figure of 'over half' of the world's population now living in 'urban areas' – based on a frequently recycled UN report from 2014 – is arguably less interesting than the questions it raises about what 'urban area' means and the extent to which this population pattern actually corresponds to any shared experience of urban life. Scholarly agendas in urban studies have grappled with these issues from multiple and overlapping theoretical paradigms in the past decade (ranging from the resurgence of Marxist urban geography after the financial crisis, to postcolonial and comparative approaches, actor-network and assemblage theories), but the current moment seems particularly focused on epistemological questions about the extent to which the 'city' is still a coherent analytical category (see Scott and Storper 2015).

Questioning the conceptual usefulness of inherited morphological definitions of the city, some theorists view our age as one of 'planetary urbanisation' in which the 'urban' as a process transcends the traditional urban/rural divide (see Brenner and Schmid 2015). Paradoxically, perhaps, such paradigm-shifting declarations dismiss the city as an analytical category, while at the same time valorising the urban as an all-encompassing process. Moreover, the planetary metaphor privileges particular

forms of visible change by evoking a perspective from outer space in which the whole surface of the planet looks urbanised (see Merrifield 2013). The current expansion of the ‘operational landscapes’ of cities beyond their bounded entity, however, is largely facilitated by the invisible infrastructures of communication technologies. To the extent that digital media flows are replacing the stimuli of the crowd – once an integral part of ‘the mental life of the metropolis’ – new forms of urban consciousness may seem less grounded in place than in disembodied connectivity. At the same time, the explosion in apps with GPS functions underlines the intertwined nature of physical and digital space and suggests that technology is used not as a retreat from particular ways of urban living, but as a means to maximising their potential. Indeed, traditional understandings of cities as dense and diverse sites of encounter, conflict, desire, dreams and myth-making still seem to dominate global popular culture, while many urban cores that suffered post-industrial decline are being repopulated and gentrified.

As these debates show, the spatial relationships between audience, moving image and urban environment are in the process of transformation. In light of these changes, can we still speak of a ‘cinematic city’? From one perspective, the rapid transformations we have sketched above suggest a need to reformulate our research agendas, theories and methodologies and challenge us to rethink our approach to contemporary cities and their audiovisual cultures. This collection brings together innovative scholarship on twenty-first-century cinema and media that engages with these questions at a global scale. At the same time, we emphasise continuity as well as change in our accounts of these shifts and stress the importance of placing contemporary cinema and screen cultures within a broader historical field. The feature film format and theatrical exhibition persist, even if the social and aesthetic practices traditionally demarcated by ‘cinema’ appear to become residual rather than dominant features of our culture. Likewise, while rapid urbanisation at a global scale blurs the conceptual and experiential boundaries of the urban, the notion of ‘the city’ and the image of individual cities nevertheless retain demonstrable currency and imaginative power for their inhabitants, visitors, governments, policymakers and planners. The city remains a vital framework for orienting our spatial experience, just as the accumulated legacy of the cinema continues to shape our relationship to images, sounds and narratives. This collection therefore argues for the continued relevance of the ‘cinematic city’ as an object of study and an academic paradigm, while acknowledging a pressing need to update and revise it.

As Barbara Klinger reminds us, films have long been experienced in the domestic setting of the home as well as the public sphere of the theatre. In fact, as Klinger suggests, non-theatrical exhibition has a complex and diverse history, whether one takes into account early home viewing systems or the variety of public spaces used for exhibition, from airplanes and ocean liners to prisons and churches (2006: 3–5). From this perspective, the contemporary explosion in portable screens, public displays, digital streaming and pop-up cinemas extends and amplifies an already-existing relationship

between the moving image and urban space that goes beyond the dichotomy of the theatre and the living room. Nevertheless, such a proliferation of films across the blurred boundaries of public and private has reconfigured the cinematic experience in ways that are yet to be fully explored. This dispersal of audiovisual material across multiple screens and sites throughout the urban environment arguably makes the city *more*, rather than less, cinematic. Less bounded in space and time, the moving image inhabits the city in new configurations and patterns. Our continued usage of the term 'cinematic' is therefore intended to situate our intervention within an existing academic literature on cinema and the city, rather than to draw a sharp dividing line between cinema and other media forms. Indeed, the contributions to this book investigate moving images and screens in a variety of contexts, from films to serial television drama, public displays to gallery installations.

As the contributions to this collection demonstrate, the city is a crucial subject, setting and narrative landscape for contemporary cinema, which continues to create new stories and images of urban life while refashioning genres and tropes that have shaped our experience of cities over the twentieth century. The global cinematic city of the twenty-first century is a flexible city of multiple screens and modes of access, a programmable city of festivals, seasons and symposia, and a branded city of transnational media production and film offices. It is in this spirit that we retain the term cinematic city, while cross-pollinating it with the 'global city'.

GLOBAL CITIES, WORLD CINEMAS

The range of geographical contexts considered in this volume is intended to rebalance some of the implicit Eurocentric tendencies of the literature on (post)modernity and the cinematic city, which has tended to focus on paradigmatic European and American cities. The continued reinvigoration of the cinema and the city field is in no small part down to the expansion of the geographical scope of the literature, which now extends firmly beyond Euro-America. Yet with few exceptions (for example, Prakash 2010), the recent decentring of the cinematic city has tended to take the form of journal articles on individual cities or monographs on specific urban contexts (see Mazumdar 2007; Braester 2010; Kuoshu 2010; Conde 2012). By presenting a global constellation of cinematic cities within one volume, this book encourages juxtapositions and comparisons of megacities, urban conurbations and 'ordinary cities' across five continents.

It goes without saying that any book with global aspirations cannot be exhaustive in terms of coverage, but inspired by Dudley Andrew's call for an 'Atlas of World Cinema', we have followed the motto: 'Displacement, not coverage, matters most' (2004: 10). Andrew argued specifically for a 'dynamic and comparative' approach that 'would track a process of cross-pollination that bypasses national directives' (ibid.). This scholarly agenda chimes with the ongoing calls in urban studies for

comparative approaches that move beyond paradigmatic case studies in favour of careful analyses of the flows of capital and people that interconnect cities across the globe (see Robinson 2011). The comparative spirit takes many forms and, in this book, ranges from explicitly dual framings that contrast urban contexts to ideas and trends such as the ‘composite city’, multi-city plots, the recycling and remediation of earlier cinematic and visual cultures, diasporic audiences and the impact of transnational production and distribution contexts on urban imaginaries. What unites these approaches is a sense that neither the lens of national cinema nor single-city frameworks can capture the transnational dynamics of contemporary urban cinema.

In film studies, the idea of the ‘cinematic city’ emerged from scholarship that situated early cinema within the critical frame of modernity (see Brunsdon 2012; Elsaesser in this volume). However, as other critics have argued, using modernity as a *singular* concept suggests a teleology of Western development and sidelines locally specific encounters with modernity – or *modernities* – in both non-Western and non-metropolitan contexts. While there has been a proliferation of work in recent years that address these Eurocentric biases by exploring modernities in a wide range of geographical contexts, the term’s associations with capitalist enterprise and new state formations makes it, in Dipesh Chakrabarty’s words, ‘impossible to *think* of anywhere in the world without invoking certain categories and concepts, the genealogies of which go deep into the intellectual and even theological traditions of Europe’ (2000: 3–4). Indeed, even attempts to provincialise Europe or the US have inadvertently, perhaps, supported a separation of the ‘West from the rest’. The affirmative term ‘world cinema’, for example, has often been defined negatively as everything which is not Hollywood and, therefore, reinforced a binary world-view in ‘which Hollywood is the centre and all other cinemas are the periphery’ (Nagib 2006: 30).

Similarly, in urban studies, the analytical focus on concepts such as modernity and development has to a large extent separated the study of cities in the global North and South into distinct and incommensurable fields (see Robinson 2011). Current postcolonial research agendas have instead tried to destabilise the South/North division by advocating an epistemological shift ‘from the postcolonial as an urban condition to the postcolonial as a critical, deconstructive methodology’ (Roy 2011: 308). In this context, the overdetermined prisms of ‘formality’ and ‘informality’, often mapped uncritically onto the North/South binary, have been rethought as practices rather than territorial formations (see McFarlane 2012). This conceptual recalibration can also be usefully deployed in analyses of the global film industry where informal production and distribution contexts often intersect with formalised transnational forms of distribution, making the boundaries between the formal and informal economy increasingly porous.

The overarching agenda of thinking across the North and South – without neglecting the uneven legacy of colonialism – is also necessary to capture the

interdependent dynamics of exchange, hybridity and circulation of the contemporary cinematic city. Unlike earlier debates about anticolonial resistance to particular forms (the escapism of the Hollywood film and the individualism of European auteur cinema), the emphasis on hybridity and vernaculars in many of the chapters in this collection instead stresses how tropes and genres are re-appropriated in different contexts. For example, several contributors draw attention to the formulaic, but awe-inspiring convention of capturing the city from above in aerial or high angle shots. While the frequent emphasis on tall buildings in these vistas could be seen as a form of as a form of 'Manhattanisation', this imagery of global urbanism is also deployed to challenge discourses of backwardness. Often addressed to the urban middle-class, including particular takes on the 'creative class', these films can be seen to participate in ongoing attempts to move beyond understandings of urbanisation in the global South solely in terms of despair, poverty and dystopia.

To negotiate this terrain, this book adopts the global city as its organising framework, a move that allows both Hollywood and European cinemas to be decentred and repositioned within a world map of economic flows, cultural exchanges and shifting centre-periphery dynamics. Drawing on recent scholarship that has reconceptualised world cinema within the framework of the transnational (Đurovičová and Newman 2009; Galt and Schoonover 2010; Iordanova, Jones and Vidal 2010), this focus on global – rather than 'world' – cinema enables us to interrogate cinemas and spatialities outside the North Atlantic without neglecting the importance of Europe and the United States (for other significant examples of this approach, see Krause and Petro 2003; Kapur and Wagner 2011). In urban studies, the 'global city' is mainly associated with Saskia Sassen's influential definition in *The Global City: New York, London, Tokyo* (1991), which had a narrow focus on financial services. While Sassen's original analysis contained strong elements of political critique (not least with regards to intra-urban class polarisation), the same cannot be said about the work of the financial consultancies that subsequently appropriated her methods to produce urban league tables. Thus the term's association with rankings – or the terminology of 'core' and 'peripheral' in John Friedmann's related 'world city hypothesis' (1986) – could potentially be seen to reproduce hierarchies and binaries associated with the North/South split. Yet since Sassen's initial intervention, the world has grown more polycentric: in 1990, five per cent of the world's five hundred largest corporations were based in emerging regions, while in 2010 the figure had reached 17 per cent and research by the McKinsey Global Institute (see Dobbs *et al.* 2012) inspired by Sassen's methodology suggests it could reach 45 per cent by 2025. These economic figures are matched by the rising cultural and cinematic importance of emerging cities and urban regions, which now compete with long-established hubs of film production and cultural prestige such as Los Angeles and Paris.

From an industrial perspective, film production is increasingly mobile on an international scale. While city and state governments worldwide compete for the global traffic of location shooting, the digital workflow of post-production, especially

visual effects, is also outsourced and dispersed across national borders (Miller *et al.* 2005). However, these interactions do not take place on a smooth and undifferentiated world map, but rather on one with competing centres of gravity and concentrations of power. Production patterns are shaped by state and city incentives as well as the presence of major studio complexes which trade on their relationship to local film industries, infrastructure, built environments and natural resources. As Ben Goldsmith and Tom O'Regan (2003) have shown, studio complexes are not, therefore, 'anywhere but nowhere' but rather 'anywhere and somewhere' – that is, their location and connection to place is a highly significant part of their strategic importance. Though many of these complexes have traditionally been in Western settings – especially the US, Canada, Europe and Australasia – centres such as Qingdao Oriental Movie Metropolis are creating new regional hubs. Expanding beyond film production into other creative industries such as fashion, design and architectural services, such complexes become clusters of activity that mirror the film festival at the other end of the consumption chain.

These intensified flows of transnational production are created and attracted by global cities that Michael Curtin designates 'media capitals'. As Curtin's research demonstrates, cities such as Bombay, Cairo or Hong Kong now 'represent centers of media activity that have specific logics of their own; ones that do not necessarily correspond to the geography, interests or policies of particular nation states.' (2003: 203). Curtin's analysis explicitly draws on Sassen, though as he suggests, her work and that of other economists and geographers frequently downplays cultural forces in their analysis of the global city. Just as geographies of film production have been uneven, so have the distribution of narrative settings. For example, Hollywood's economic hegemony has allowed it to export an Americanised view of urbanism for global consumption. Preceding recent discussion on the 'generic city' (Koolhaas 1995) – a term several contributors in this book deploy – Fredric Jameson noted early in relation to postmodern cinema the tendency to represent urban space *everywhere* as if it were New York or California (1982: 116). In contrast with this homogenisation, Giuliana Bruno's influential analysis of *Blade Runner* (Ridley Scott, 1982) stressed an eclectic urban hybridity as she highlighted how the film is set in a city 'called Los Angeles, but it is an LA that looks very much like New York, Hong Kong, or Tokyo' (1987: 65). What these two seemingly contradictory – but not incompatible – trends of global homogenisation and local hybridisation have in common is that they challenge place-specificity. For many commentators, this perceived crisis of the particularity of place – frequently held up as a hallmark of our current round of globalisation – has been intensified by the digital revolution, which is also seen to disembed social relations from physical locations.

As numerous scholars have argued, however, this narrative has frequently been overstated: in fact, place specificity and the embeddedness of urban cultures and economies may matter more, rather than less, in the context of these globalising forces (see Massey 1994; Sassen 2005). Revising our understanding of cinema and

space in the contemporary conjuncture therefore requires attention to this complex imbrication of the material and the immaterial, the global and the local. One aspect of this reconfiguration is the extent to which the digital turn has threatened the indexical link to geographical place – a persistent theme in discussions of the cinematic city. Following Siegfried Kracauer's emphasis on film's affinity for 'the street' and the camera's capacity to record and reveal its material reality, the ontology of the location has underscored the conceptual link between medium and place. As John David Rhodes and Elena Gorfinkel argue, this 'very natural seeming predisposition of the moving image toward an indexical recording of place' (2011: xvi) provokes important questions about the way that place is embedded in the effects of the cinematic apparatus. In the digital era, such questions are equally important but may need to be reformulated. From a conceptual perspective, the digital camera and the endless manipulability of the image weaken or even break the photographic bond to the profilmic location, while the studio has become a virtual as well as a physical space.

However, this account becomes problematic if one takes a more pragmatic view. Just as soundstage work and special effects processes were carefully integrated with location footage in the past, behind-the-scenes reels from contemporary VFX houses have shown just how much of a film's *mise-en-scène* can be manipulated and redesigned in post-production in ways that are consonant with audience expectations of authenticity. Both traditional studio production and contemporary filmmaking practices produce space by integrating heterogeneous materials with varying levels of perceived realism. Though more research remains to be done to investigate the nature of these shifts, it seems premature to suggest that the link between viewer and place has been severed.

Indeed, despite recent media debates about the over-use of CGI and audience demands for greater authenticity, the experiential relationship between cinema and place appears as strong as ever. Even Hollywood's most CGI-heavy franchises can become powerful engines of movie tourism, and there is little evidence to suggest that audiences are less interested in the relationship between film and place, which if anything, appears to be intensifying. For a major release, shooting locations are frequently recorded on the Internet Movie Database before a film hits cinemas, their coordinates plotted and digitally mapped, and their relation to 'real' places debated and dissected by bloggers, fans and local media. Mapping movie locations, once the preserve of fans and scholars, has now become part of the everyday practice of film consumption, and the paratextual materials that have proliferated in the digital era frequently operate in ways that could be considered spatial or cartographic. We might also consider Intellect's burgeoning World Film Locations series, a semi-scholarly list currently at forty volumes and counting, whose titles read like an airport departure board or a chart of popular city break destinations; in this sense, being viewed as 'cinematic' might be understood as a necessary precondition for global city status.

OVERVIEW

The book's opening section focuses on evolving patterns of production, distribution and exhibition. In the first chapter, Thomas Elsaesser advances the international film festival as a model for revising our understanding of both the 'cinematic city' and European cinema. Our concepts of the cinematic city, Elsaesser argues, must be reworked in the era of the post-industrial or global city, which has seen a fundamental reconfiguration of urban societies and their relationship to cinema as culture, institution and economic agent. For Elsaesser, film festivals provide the clearest way to remap these relationships while revising our understanding of European cinema as part of an encompassing notion of 'world cinema'. Simultaneously global, regional and urban, this is a European cinema of the cities appropriate to the age of cultural capitals and city branding initiatives. In navigating this field, Elsaesser draws on two modalities of the global city – the generic city (Rem Koolhaas) and the cluster city (Michael Porter) – each of which help to illuminate the role of the film festival within contemporary cinema and cities. This focus on the film festival enables us to understand the cinematic city as institutional fixture as much as representational trope. Kant's paradox of world citizenship – the paradigm of 'unsocial sociability' – becomes a way to recast apparently oppositional relationships (for example, between Hollywood and international art cinema) as systems of productive feedback and what Elsaesser defines as 'antagonistic mutuality'. The film festival therefore emerges as an emblematic phenomenon of the global, 'programmed' city and a key nodal point in the global/local dynamics of contemporary cinema.

In the second chapter, Pei-Sze Chow develops this transnational theme, examining television production and media policy in the Øresund city region (encompassing Copenhagen and Malmö). How do city regions impact on media production and can narrative forms give shape to new urban-regional identities? Focusing on the crime thriller *Bron/Broen* (2011–), a Swedish-Danish co-production, Chow outlines the industrial and institutional contexts for transnational programming. As she argues, *Bron/Broen* is not only a product of regional policy, but also self-consciously addresses the construction of a new regional identity. Yet this transnational imaginary is harder to assemble than the region's planners and technocrats might wish it to be: the faultlines of the Øresund come to the surface in the show, which uses the long-form possibilities of the serial drama and the transnational 'Nordic Noir' aesthetic to explore the fractures between city, region and nation.

Mapping out new industry dynamics and production trends in the Nigerian film industry, including expansion from Lagos into locations such as Asaba and Onitsha, Jonathan Haynes's chapter examines how Nollywood has been shaped by the distinctive experience of neoliberalism in West Africa. Yet this highly embedded national industry is also being transformed by the role of transnational corporations, which are seeking to formalise distribution via satellite and streaming services such as Netflix, not least to target crucial African diasporic audiences globally. As Haynes's

close reading of recent films reveal, the narrative themes of Nollywood also reflect these audience maximisation strategies. *Lagos Cougars* (Desmond Elliot, 2013), for example, is divided between an affluent neighbourhood in Lagos and the prosperous Nigerian community in Houston, Texas, while the corporate style of *Last Flight to Abuja* (Obi Emelonye, 2012) challenges the trope of Africa as backward in order to appeal to both domestic and expatriate pride.

The three chapters in the second section engage with Buenos Aires, Los Angeles and Kolkata, focusing on films that revise or repurpose the traditional screen image of those cities. Drawing on contemporary spatial and media theories, these chapters stake out ways in which cinema engages with gentrification, globalisation and digitisation in the global city. For Joanna Page, *Medianeras* (Gustavo Taretto, 2011) is representative of a new wave of films that move beyond familiar cinematic images of Buenos Aires as a city of poverty, exclusion and marginalisation. In contrast, *Medianeras* inhabits the world of a relatively affluent, professional class of post-industrial workers whose city is saturated by digital media. This highly mediated environment is established through a heterogeneous audiovisual language that features techniques more often associated with architectural animation and television advertising. Drawing on recent work on media ecologies, Page shows how the film and its reflexive participation in the aesthetics of intermediality invokes the city as a place in which the virtual and the material, the human and nonhuman encounter each other in complex ways.

This exploration of post-human subjectivity and the digital city continues in Lawrence Webb's analysis of *Her* (Spike Jonze, 2013) and its projection of human/operating system romance in near-future Los Angeles. Viewing Jonze's film as a hybrid of romantic comedy and science fiction, Webb discusses its repurposing of genre conventions in the context of the digital turn, the creative class, and the hybridisation of the global city. While the film's use of Shanghai locations makes a new intervention into the urban imaginary of Los Angeles, its debt to *Blade Runner* and *Metropolis* (Fritz Lang, 1927) shows how the digital city is nevertheless figured through the representational tropes and legacies of the cinematic city.

Malini Guha's chapter turns to Kolkata's 'middle of the road' cinema and a cycle of films for, and about, the city's middle class population. As she argues, films such as *The Future of the Past* (Anik Dutta, 2012) and *Maach, Mishri and More* (Mainak Bhaumik, 2013) deploy cinephilic references to Bengali film history – especially the work of Parallel Cinema auteurs such as Satyajit Ray and Ritwik Ghatak – as a central strategy in their engagement with Kolkata's rapidly changing urban environment. Mapping cinephilia onto the concept of topophilia, Guha shows how the city's cinematic legacy has become intertwined with contemporary discourses about Kolkata's postcolonial transformation. As Guha argues, the cinephilic gestures of these films are frequently topophilic, evoking nostalgic longings for the particularity of place in the face of globalisation. Considering the ambivalent politics of these films, Guha questions what is at stake in this cinephilic and topophilic mobilisation

of the urban past and its relation to the city's projected future.

The third section expands the book's focus beyond cinema to contemplate the broader relationship between the global city, screens and new media. Chris Berry takes a comparative view of public screens in Shanghai and Cairo, questioning how the post-cinematic screen culture of the glance relates to the contemporary global city. Contesting received ideas about the ubiquity of media in the city and notions of the generic city, Berry's research outlines the local specificity of urban screens and their uses. The case studies of Shanghai and Cairo demonstrate that screens are far from ubiquitous, and their patterns of use attest to diverse and specific local cultures rather than homogeneity. Ultimately, these local cultures and their experiences and appropriations of public space provide an optimistic view that neoliberal screen culture, and its encroaching commodification of urban space, might yet be challenged.

Yomi Braester argues that the contemporary urban environment is defined by two forms of the moving image, surveillance videos and found footage. Rather than view these in opposition, Braester suggests that they are complementary, blurring boundaries between public and private spheres, spontaneous and designed images, and between material and virtual spaces. Braester examines these interlinked phenomena in the People's Republic of China, analysing selfies and self-made videos alongside contemporary video art by Tan Tan, Li Juchuan and Ai Weiwei. As these examples show, citizens are not simply subjects of surveillance or masters of their own visual representation. Rather, the interaction between subjects, screens and cameras is mutually constitutive – a process that redefines and reconstitutes public space and urban citizenship. Like Joanna Page, Braester invokes the notion of a new media ecology, conceptualising the city as a 'visual ecosystem' that functions both as 'watching eye and as a visual *objet trouvé*'.

Igor Krstić analyses the photographer Jonas Bendiksen's transmedia work *The Places We Live* (2008) and its engagement with slums in Mumbai, Caracas, Nairobi and Jakarta. This project, which began as a photo book and later developed into an interactive web documentary and immersive touring installation, can be seen as a process of remediation in two ways. As Krstić shows, it refashions earlier representations of slums, notably Jacob Riis's *How the Other Half Lives* (1890) and other spectacular images of urban poverty from the nineteenth century. At the same time, Bendiksen's work 'remediates' in the sense of reform, in its attempt to provide positive counter-narratives to the dystopian notion of a 'planet of slums' popularised by Mike Davis and others. By unpacking the different experiences of this project as photography, interactive documentary and panoramic installation, Krstić questions whether this remediation of slum imagery can provide a critical edge, or if it is just the latest and most hypermediated example of slum tourism for Western audiences.

The final section is concerned with the narrative topographies and spatial trajectories of contemporary cinema. Will Higbee shows how recent films have moved beyond established narrative spaces and representational tropes associated

with the immigrant experience in France. Whereas the *beur* cinema of the 1980s and the *banlieue* films of the 1990s represented housing estates on the urban periphery as an emblematic space of social exclusion, recent films have deployed settings that Higbee calls ‘interstitial cityscapes’ outside the global cities of Paris and Marseilles. Drawing on the work of Hamid Naficy, Higbee argues that films such as *Dernier Maquis* (Rabah Ameur-Zaimeche, 2008), *La Graine et la mule* (Abdellatif Kechiche, 2007) and *Rust and Bone* (Jacques Audiard, 2012) are set in spaces characterised by multiple points of identification, which problematise the relationship between place and ethnic belonging/exclusion. Similarly, Jinhee Choi’s chapter maps the urban spaces in contemporary South Korean gangster films by appropriating Edward Dimendberg’s conceptual typology of centripetal and centrifugal space in relation to Seoul and Busan. As Choi argues, the spatial trajectories of these gangster and noir films in which characters often trespass both vertical and horizontal boundaries underline tensions around social immobility in South Korean society. Adding an industry dimension to her analysis of the settings in these films, Choi also draws attention to a shift from Seoul to Busan as a key location in the 2000s as a direct result of the local government’s efforts to attract filmmaking to the city.

Finally, the Hollywood film industry is, of course, still hegemonic in terms of economic power, cultural influence and market saturation. Yet, though the industry remains firmly anchored in the management, design and production complex of Southern California, its operational logic has become increasingly decentred through the need to attract global audiences, especially in rapidly expanding markets such as China. Hollywood production practices have long been internationally mobile, though their global strategies continue to evolve. Christian Long tackles this topic via one of the key modalities of Hollywood blockbuster urbanism: the city-hopping itineraries of the global spy thriller. As Long argues, the tendency for the spy film to shoot chase sequences in the megacities of the global South is motivated not only by cheap labour but also by a complex mesh of generic requirements and logistical strategies. Going beyond purely economic accounts of runaway production, Long shows how the built topography and transport infrastructure of a city such as Tangier or Manila offer fresh possibilities for staging action. The global megacity thus becomes an infrastructural resource for Hollywood, binding together economics and aesthetics, ideology and geopolitics.

NOTE

- 1 The literature is now extensive. In film studies, the idea of the ‘cinematic city’ emerged from scholarship that situated early cinema within the critical paradigm of modernity (see Hansen 1991; Bruno 1993; Gunning 1994; Charney and Schwartz 1995; Donald 1999). The first generation of edited books on cinema and the city, which appeared in the late 1990s and early 2000s (see Clarke 1997;

Shiel and Fitzmaurice 2001; 2003), were genuinely interdisciplinary attempts to merge insights from the humanities and social sciences and drew inspiration from the modernity/modernism debates as well as an interdisciplinary literature on postmodernity and postmodern urbanism (see Jameson 1984, 1992; Harvey 1989; Davis 1990; Soja 1996; Bruno 1987; Deutsche 1996). These anthologies have been followed by many important contributions to the field, including surveys of urban cinema (see AlSayyad 2006; Mennel 2008), studies of individual cities (see Brunsdon 2007; Braester 2010; Shiel 2012), in-depth analyses of genres, cycles and periods (see Dimendberg 2004; Prakash 2010; Wojcik 2010; Corkin 2011; Webb 2014), theories of cinema and space (see Pratt and San Juan, 2014) and edited collections with varying emphases (see Konstantarakos 2000; Webber and Wilson 2008; Braester and Tweedie 2010; Rhodes and Gorfinkel 2011). See also Brunsdon (2012) for a detailed genealogy of this scholarship.

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SCREEN CULTURES AND THE 'GENERIC CITY': PUBLIC SCREENS IN CAIRO AND SHANGHAI

CHRIS BERRY

INTRODUCTION

The post-industrial city is also, in a sense, post-cinematic. If you believe that cinema requires celluloid, in many global cities today you will struggle to find a cinema projecting a celluloid print of a film. If you associate moving images with the gaze at the movie screen, as theorised by Laura Mulvey (1975), or even at the television receiver in your living room, that experience has become the exception rather than the norm. Not only have multiple windows open all at once on computer screens and tablets become our primary objects of attention, moving images have also moved out of the movie theatre and the living room, proliferating across screens of all kinds in public spaces. As Francesco Casetti (2013) has argued, the cinematic culture of the gaze has been superseded by the post-cinematic screen culture of the glance. What is the relationship of this new post-cinematic screen culture of the glance to the contemporary global city?

To begin to answer this question, this essay draws on research about public screens some colleagues and I have conducted in Shanghai and Cairo.¹ First, I consider the common assumption that under conditions of globalisation, media become ubiquitous and participate in a process of homogenising the city. Instead, I argue that, in the case of public screens at least, the evidence indicates that they are concentrated at particular locations and far from ubiquitous. Furthermore, the most common uses of moving image screens in public spaces that we were able to identify indicate a considerable degree of localisation. In Cairo, this is the use of the screen as a television receiver, often in the form of a cathode ray set, in small retail stores, *ahwa*

cafés and coffee shops. In Shanghai, localisation takes the form of the proliferation of two types of screen at entrances to office and residential compounds, shops, and even public transport vehicles. These are slide-show style screens and tickertape-style screens. The latter are known in Chinese as *zouzi* or 'walking word' screens.

Second, I argue that the global city is also the city of neoliberalism. I go on to engage with debates on the nature of neoliberalism. Some scholars, such as Francis Fukuyama (1992), have celebrated the neoliberal culture of globalisation and others, such as Guy Debord (1998), have lamented it, but both tend to see it as a total and eternal regime with no outside, marking the point where politics and history end. In line with my argument on localisation, I argue that although the everyday uses of public screens in Shanghai and Cairo are most often part of neoliberal culture, they also demonstrate that neoliberal cultures are plural and not homogenous. This diversity in itself indicates that contestation and change may not be over yet. Furthermore, I argue that unexpected everyday uses of public screens in Cairo and Shanghai's retail and recreation sites of consumerism, along with exceptional uses of the space, also indicate that neoliberalism may be more fragile than is often thought.

GLOBALISATION, UBIQUITY, AND THE 'GENERIC CITY'

In his essay on contemporary screen cultures, Francesco Casetti not only argues that we glance rather than gaze at many screens, but also notes that digitised images are in the air, everywhere, in their invisible electronic form. We live among them, they pass through us, and the screens act like lightning rods that draw the images out of the air and make them visible to us (2013: 13). This very striking imagery echoes some contemporary theorisations of media and the city. First there is the idea – and sometimes ideal – of 'ubiquitous media' (see Featherstone 2009); for example, instead of the phone anchored to the landline, our mobile phones draw audio out of the air and into our ears almost anywhere we like. Second, this ubiquity is a characteristic of the rise of what Harvard professor and star architect of signature buildings like the China Central Television headquarters in Beijing, Rem Koolhaas, calls the 'generic city' (1995). Here, one city looks much the same as another, and cities no longer have distinctive sectors but are becoming a generalised sprawl of offices, factories and apartment buildings. Koolhaas's insights are heavily based on his own observation of the Pearl River Delta, where he has done a lot of work.

However, our data on public screens in Shanghai and Cairo contests both ubiquity and the idea of the generic city. This became clear in the beginning stages of our project. Our method involved three steps in each city. First, we had an exploratory stage based on random walking and inspired by the *dérive* associated with Situationism (see Debord 1981). Second, we carried out an 'audit' of screens in selected sites. We selected three types of site: retail and recreation centres; public exhibition sites like museums; and transport hubs like train stations. Third, we also

pursued close observation of selected individual screens at our sites. All this work has been taking place over a number of years, and has been supplemented with some interviews, as has been detailed elsewhere (see Berry and Harbord 2015).

In the initial walking stages of the project, we soon discovered that although the images may be everywhere in the air, the lighting rod-like screens that make them visible certainly are not. For example, in Cairo on 3 March 2010, I embarked on a random walk by taking the metro to a station I had never alighted from before – El Khalafawi on line number two – and then walked around the neighbourhood for a couple of hours. This was a residential area, and on the basis of the cries of ‘Welcome to Egypt!’ from various young men, I got the impression foreigners were not a common sight. Throughout the walk, I saw no large screens on the sides of buildings or screens being used to offer information, only the screens of television receivers inside stores and cafés. In Shanghai, on 6 November 2008, I set out east from Fudan University in the northeast part of the city, and, after walking a short distance to the Wujiaochang intersection, where there were numerous stores, cinemas, restaurants, and so on, turned south and walked all the way down Siping Road until I got to Tongji University. While there were many screens of all kinds at the Wujiaochang intersection, I did not encounter another screen until I arrived at the entrance of Tongji University, where a large screen inside the entrance proclaimed it to be a ‘world-famous university’ and also aired other information.

Indeed, it was the rapid realisation that screens were *not* ubiquitous that led us to select the three types of site for audits in the second stage of our data collection, because these places are where screens congregate. Installing a public screen of any size is not cost-free, and the large screens installed on the sides of some buildings are expensive. In these circumstances, it is not surprising that screens tend to be found in areas that large numbers of people pass through. In the case of these two walks, the example would be the Wujiaochang intersection, the retail and recreation hub for the Yangpu District of Shanghai. Two large and highly luminescent screens topped department stores facing each other across the intersection, creating focal points in a riotous lightscape composed of traffic lights, neon, and numerous smaller screens.

However, it is also clear that numbers of people alone are not enough to merit the installation of LED public screens. During my walk through the El Khalafawi neighbourhood, I passed through a busy street market, which was at least as thronged as the Wujiaochang intersection. Yet, screens were confined to television receivers inside some shops along the street. Neither the Yangpu District nor the El Khalafawi neighbourhoods are rich, so what accounts for this difference? Perhaps ordinary people in Shanghai do have more disposable income than their Cairo counterparts. But it is also significant that Wujiaochang has been designated a ‘sub-centre’ of Shanghai (Zhong 2009: 113), intended to drive the regeneration of a neighbourhood marked by relatively high unemployment following the closure of the textile factories that used to dominate the neighbourhood (see Zhang 2009). In other words, Wujiaochang is aspirational, its redevelopment is designed to make it attractive to upscale residents

and service their needs, and investment in LED screens is one way of signifying that aspiration.

The clustering of public screens in areas of high traffic and potential high yield to advertisers is also confirmed by the practices of the NASDAQ-listed company, Focus Media, which pioneered installing public screens for advertising purposes in Shanghai beginning in 2002. They aimed initially at the white collar end of the market, in the belief that this is the most lucrative segment but also the most difficult to reach, because, according to CEO Jason Jiang, 'High income earners are very busy, they don't have much time to read newspapers or watch TV at home' (in Madden 2006). Therefore, Focus did not try to put their screens everywhere, but instead installed them strategically, next to the elevator doors in office buildings, as well as golf clubs, beauty salons and so forth (see Massy 2005).

If public screens are not ubiquitous, perhaps the emphasis on advertising in the above paragraphs might suggest that they are used in pretty much the same way no matter where they are, making them part of the generic city. However, again, our data indicates a more complex situation. In this regard, the deployment of public screens can be seen as part of the debates about the nature of globalisation. During the era of territorial empire, innovations and inventions originated in the metropolis, and then were gradually rolled out to the peripheries. But today, the same technology is available almost simultaneously anywhere around the world. Is this also part of the trend towards the generic city? Arjun Appadurai (1990) writes of globalisation as characterised by transborder flows, but he also argues that as the flows encounter the local, the result is not homogenisation or the production of the generic, but heterogenisation. Similarly, Roland Robertson (1995) coined the English term 'globalisation' to characterise this process, identified originally by Japanese researchers.

Examples to support the idea of local specificity in screen culture are numerous, and two types of localisation can be noted. The first invokes singularity, the very opposite of the generic. This is the concept of site specificity, argued for by Anna McCarthy (2001) in her pioneering work on cathode ray television sets in public spaces in the United States. McCarthy observed that to understand what was on each cathode ray television set, how it was being used, where it was positioned, and so forth required close attention to the specific site it was located in. In other words, one doctor's office was *not* pretty much like any other. The same is true of each contemporary LED public screen. They come in different shapes and sizes, carry different content, and are positioned according to the specificities of the local topography and demography.

Nevertheless, from a perspective that wishes to emphasise the generic, it might be possible to argue that the distinctions of local topography are minor variations within a generic sea of advertising featuring global brands and styles. However, our data demonstrates that, patterns of screen usage are also part of ever-changing and diverse but specific local cultures. To illustrate this second argument about local specificity, we can turn to the most common types and uses of public screens in Cairo

and Shanghai, which are quite distinct. Although this would have to be checked with further research, these patterns may well be found in other cities in each region.

First, in Cairo, although large public screens are relatively rare, small screens being used as television receivers in the manner studied in the United States by McCarthy are very common. They appear most frequently in three types of publicly accessible site: shops, *ahwa* cafés and coffee shops. These are sometimes small flat screen televisions, and sometimes cathode ray sets. Their presence is a product of the everyday retail and recreation environment in Cairo. First, the retail sector is dominated by small shops, with seventy per cent of grocery stores in independent hands as of 2013. The self-service culture of supermarkets is not common yet. In these circumstances, shopping is a social interaction. There is no self-checkout option with machines barking strange phrases like ‘unexpected item in bagging area’, as encountered in London, where I live. Instead, a purchase entails at least a minimal conversation with the shopkeeper, who may well also be a neighbour. The television gives the customer something to watch while waiting for the shopkeeper to get the requested goods, or something to talk about if he has an assistant who does the fetching. And, of course, it also gives the shopkeeper something to watch during the slow periods. It is relatively affordable, and it can be set to whatever channel the shopkeeper chooses.

Small screens, usually functioning as television receivers, are also found in *ahwa* cafés and coffee shops. In a culture where few people consume alcohol, especially in public, these carry some of the same social functions as the American bar or British pub. Every neighbourhood has many *ahwa*, and these are usually establishments where only men gather. More recently, they have been supplemented by a middle class culture of international-style coffee shops, where both men and women gather (see Peterson 2009; de Koning 2011). Ratiba Hadj-Moussa (2010) has written about how, before the arrival of the satellite dish in Algeria, domestic space was female and men were expected to spend most of their time outside the home, returning to eat and sleep. Although satellite dishes are also common in Egypt, it seems a similar gendered pattern still applies. In a city where there is a great deal of both under-employment and unemployment, the *ahwa* is a place where men can pass time at relatively little cost. The television set is a relatively low-cost investment that gives customers something to talk about and something to watch when they do not want to talk or if they are alone. Special television events, like football matches, also draw customers to the *ahwa*, much as they do in bars and pubs elsewhere.

In contrast to Cairo, television receivers in shops are less common in Shanghai. The most common use of the public screen that we found there, even in places where no other kind of public screen was situated, is to mark entrances to shops, public buildings, residential compounds, and so on. The screen at the entrance to Tongji University mentioned above, which functioned like a slide show, is one example. To give another, on 29 March 2010, local research assistant Wu Dan and I set off on another exploratory walk, to Songjiang New Town Station at the end of subway

line nine. We started out at the commercial heart of Songjiang, but there were no advertising pillars with screens embedded in them lining the sidewalks, as we saw in downtown Shanghai, nor were there screens on the sides of the buildings. But walking north from the station, we came across a 'walking word' (*zouzi*) screen featuring red characters, moving tickertape-style on a black background, over the entrance to a building supplies and decoration store, and another one over the entrance to a branch of China Construction Bank. Both advertised current offers. A bit further on, we discovered similar walking word screens at a spa and a restaurant. Apart from the eye-catching quality of movement and light, another advantage of this form of advertising is local control and the ability to change the message at will. Later informal enquiries indicated that the prices of these screens had dropped rapidly in recent years and they were considered to be affordable for most small business owners now.

Similar screens are found all over Shanghai, and all other Chinese cities that I have visited. They are the latest variant in a long history of Chinese writing in public spaces. Climb a mountain in China, and if someone else has got to the top before you, you are likely to find Chinese characters inscribed into the rock at the summit. These are called *moya*, and they have been around for at least 2,000 years. As Robert Harrist points out, they 'are traces of the mind ... imposing cultural order on the accidents of geology' (2000: 39). At lunar New Year, it is customary to stick good luck couplets written on paper on either side of the doorway to your home. This habit is believed to date back more than a thousand years, although it was only in the fourteenth century that the use of red paper by ordinary citizens became a standardised and formalised practice (see Hsieh and Chou 1981: 125). More recently, after the founding of the People's Republic, a 'blackboard newspaper' (*heibanbao*) culture developed. This medium was seen as an effective way to generate and circulate local news and to reach ordinary people who might not buy or attend to newspapers. Guidebooks on how to produce effective news blackboards have been published since the 1950s, often profusely illustrated (see Zhou 1952). These blackboards were (and sometimes still are) located at the entrances to residential areas and workplaces.

This history of writing in public can be understood with reference to Louis Althusser's (1971) concept of ideology as interpellation, or a hailing effect on the subject to whom the ideology is directed. From this perspective, the prevalence of writing in public spaces in China suggests a public culture where spaces are clearly divided and differentiated according to the roles, activities, and values expected of people in those places, which the writing communicates. The historical changes in the medium of writing, from inscription to blackboard to 'walking word' screen can also be understood through Jay David Bolter and Richard Grusin's (2000) concept of remediation of earlier media forms. However, it is important to point out that they are not simply a case of old wine in new bottles. Rather, these remediations are better understood as a genealogy, in Michel Foucault's (1977) sense that emphasises contingency and disjuncture rather than linear historical development. And implied

in the case of the transition from the blackboard to the walking word screen is the shift from socialist prioritisation of production to today's neoliberal exhortation to consumption. The second part of this essay extends the questions of the first part of this essay to neoliberal culture.

NEOLIBERALISM, THE END OF HISTORY, AND THE INTEGRATED SPECTACLE

Koolhaas's generic city is not only the city of globalisation but also the city of neoliberalism. He observes that the simultaneous arrival of cyberspace and generic sprawl means that whatever is left of public culture is on the net, and the physical spaces of the city are only for work and consumption (1995: 1250). Here, the idea of the global city as homogenised is conjoined with the idea of neoliberal culture, which is also characterised by an ideology that claims politics are over, morality is privatised, and public life is devoted to accelerated cycles of production and consumption in the pursuit of accumulation of wealth.

Neoliberalism is much debated. One of the most quoted texts on the topic is David Harvey's *A Brief History of Neoliberalism* (2005). In it he emphasises a political economic analysis of the rollback of the state and emphasis on the market as a strategy for re-entrenching global elites. A point of controversy in the book has been the inclusion of a chapter on China (2005: 121–51). Donald M. Nonini (2008) argues against the idea of China as neoliberal, on the grounds that although China has engaged with the market economy and global capitalism, the state continues to be the dominant player in the economy. Indeed, if neoliberalism is understood solely as an economic phenomenon, this argument has value.

However, if neoliberalism is also understood as a culture, then a more complex picture emerges. In *Desiring China* (2007), Lisa Rofel analyses contemporary Chinese culture as not only shaped by neoliberal practices such as the command economy giving way to a market economy and the state moving housing, healthcare, and increasingly education over to the market, but also by the adoption of an ethos that encourages people to see themselves as individuals engaged in lifelong projects of self-making, for which they are responsible, and which are to be realised through consumption. These she calls 'experiments in neoliberalism'. Once we understand neoliberalism as both economic and cultural, we can see how China has developed its own neoliberalism, and we can also acknowledge that perhaps the change from the command economy to Chinese neoliberalism has been far greater than the changes experienced in Western liberal democracies, even if the state continues to play a dominant economic role in China. Much the same can be said of Egypt, which also transitioned from a state-controlled command economy and culture inherited from Nasser to its own neoliberal economy and culture under Mubarak (see Osman 2010).

Not only is this neoliberal culture one where as much as possible is given over to market-based practices of production and consumption, but also it is also understood, by both its critics and its proponents, as a culture where there is no more political contestation. This is the argument of Francis Fukuyama's famous 'end of history' thesis (1992), where he celebrates the idea that since the fall of the Berlin wall in 1989, liberal democracy has emerged as a global winner. (This was, of course, written before 9/11, the Iraq War, the rise of Islamic State, and so on.) This vision echoes Koolhaas's vision of the generic city as one where public culture (including political contestation) has departed the public spaces of the city, and shopping is the primary public activity.

Whereas Fukuyama celebrates neoliberalism as the end of politics, others see it as a dystopia. An example is Guy Debord's idea of the 'integrated spectacle'. Debord previously described the concentrated and diffuse spectacle in an essay originally published in 1967 (see Debord 1994). The former referred to totalitarian modernity, where attention was focused on a dictatorial personality such as Stalin, Mao or Hitler, whereas the latter designated consumerist modernity characterised by advertising. Insofar as the subject might look away from the object of the gaze, there was always the possibility of disruption. However, in an essay originally published in 1992, shortly before his suicide, he argued that the victory of the diffuse spectacle had ushered in a third form, the integrated spectacle, which fuses both previous types and is global and all-encompassing (see Debord 1998). In a remark that echoes Jameson's (1991) comments on lack of critical distance in late capitalism or Baudrillard's (1983) idea of the postmodern simulacrum, Debord concludes, 'When the spectacle was concentrated, the greater part of surrounding society escaped it; when diffuse, a small part; today, no part. The spectacle has spread itself to the point where it now permeates all reality' (1998: 9).

Debord's integrated spectacle takes us back to Casetti's post-cinematic screen culture, where we live amongst images rather than gaze at them. And, indeed, the dominant deployment of public screens to promote consumption would seem to place the post-cinematic screen culture of the global city securely in the service of the neoliberal project of colonising public space for consumption. Yet, even here, our data indicates some complications. First, even the way in which screens are deployed in consumer cultures is also site-specific and culturally specific, suggesting a multiplicity of competing neoliberal cultures rather than a static and generic world where history has come to an end. And, second, perhaps today's screen culture also indicates that neoliberalism may be less monolithic than either Fukuyama or Debord believes.

To deal with local specificity first, screens are found at sites of high-end or wannabe high-end consumption in both Cairo and Shanghai, but the characteristics of these sites are quite different. In Shanghai, Wujiaochang typifies a pattern where department stores, cinemas, hotels, and so on all cluster at major intersections, and the potential consumers gather and swarm on the streets.

In Cairo, in contrast, upper middle class consumption occurs in box malls. Our

chosen research site was the City Stars Heliopolis mall. Located a short drive from the airport where the middle class suburbs of Nasr City and Heliopolis meet, it is 'certainly inspired by a pharaonic temple' (Abaza 2006: 31). City Stars sits here like a UFO that has just landed – it has little if any apparent connection to the surrounding neighbourhood. A forbidding and windowless fortress-like development, it is most easily accessed by the car-owning minority of Cairo's population, who can drive and enter from 'indoor parking facilities for over 6,000 vehicles' (Anon. 2012) underneath the building. For those who dare to approach from the street, it has a small number of well-guarded entrances, where all who enter are security checked. Nominally, it is open to all shoppers, but we never saw anyone walking in from the apartment blocks in the neighbourhood.

City Stars is not only segregated but also aspires to be somewhere else entirely. Whereas the Shanghai intersection of Wujiaochang aspires to lead the redevelopment of the entire Yangpu District of Shanghai, the Cairo box mall implies the impossibility of or lack of interest in broader social change. Like the Tardis time machine in the British television series *Doctor Who*, stepping into City Stars Heliopolis provides, for the class that can access it, the uncanny experience of being transported into an elsewhere of global brand culture with a few local touches, and without actually leaving Cairo at all. Whereas Wujiaochang is open and indeed integrated into the surrounding streets, attempting to draw the neighbourhood with it, City Stars and the other new indoor malls of Cairo are part of a logic of what Mona Abaza calls 'walling off' (2006: 26) the lives of the upper middle classes and the elite from scenes and experiences like the teeming shoppers of the market near El Khalafawi metro station.

This 'not El Khalafawi' quality of the City Stars experience extends also to its screen culture. The mall is traversed by 'boulevards', where there are many LED screens – as opposed to the cathode ray television receivers that predominate around El Khalafawi. Furthermore, these LED screens are arranged as pairs placed back-to-back in four-screen pods hanging from the ceiling. Each one of these screens featured the same mall video loop, mostly advertising the stores, facilities, and upcoming events of the mall itself, as well as some public service messages about children's healthcare and the activities of a charity. If the everyday street market is congested, the 'boulevards' of City Stars are spacious and, as the appropriation of the French word might imply, made for promenading. If the street market is hot, City Stars is air-conditioned and cool. If the street market is local and dominated by piles of produce, City Stars is cosmopolitan, almost all its wares well packaged and bearing regional and international brand names. Whereas the street spaces of the market are screen-free, but each independent shop has its own cathode ray television set, with a different programme blaring out, in City Stars there are relatively few screens inside shops, but almost the entire environment is populated by the pods of four Samsung flat screens playing the City Stars loop. Why this redundancy? Again, it contrasts with the market areas outside and is part of the overall effort to communicate City Stars Heliopolis mall as the opposite of the apparently chaotic, hot, disordered and



Fig. 1 The four-screen pods inside City Stars, Cairo, 2010.

overcrowded streets of Cairo; instead, City Stars is excessively and redundantly ordered, cool, and busy but uncongested. Doubling the screens emphasises order and control at the same time as it excludes options.

The screen culture of Wujiaochang is as devoted to aspirational consumption as that of the City Stars Heliopolis mall. But the arrangement of its screens and their signification is quite different. Not only is Wujiaochang an open space, designed to connect with and lead the Yangpu neighbourhood, but also the screens are varied in size and content. They range from the massive screens on the sides of the two department stores, with the newer one advertising global brands, to 'walking word' screens at the entrance of stores like a jewellers as well as banks and restaurants, and to pillars lining some of the streets and carrying yet more advertising on their LED screens. These screens merge with regular advertising lightboxes, streetlights, and even a network of pulsating neon over the 'egg' that encloses a road overpass arching through the space of the intersection. The result is a vibrant and diverse lightscape full of the '*renao*' (literally 'hot noise') character that Chinese people find attractive (see Warden and Chen 2009) but is so different from the cool order of the screens in City Stars.

The diversity of consumption screen cultures illustrated by the differences between Wujiaochang and City Stars indicates a diversity in neoliberal cultures that challenges the idea of neoliberal culture as monolithic. However, diversity in itself does not suggest an 'outside' to neoliberal culture. Yet, here, too, there are signs that the spectacle culture of the glance at the LED screen may not be quite as integrated

and all-encompassing as Debord feared. First of all, although City Stars may strive to make those inside it forget about the rest of Cairo, the majority of the city's citizens have very limited access to a culture of self-making through consumption.

In Shanghai, too, the many older, retired and unemployed in the areas around Wujiaochang come to the intersection in the evening, not to shop, but to dance. They bring their own boomboxes and, as the stores close, take over the areas outside to line dance and ballroom dance. The huge screens on the sides of the buildings are their spotlights, the pulsating neon patterns on the 'egg' their disco ball. These are not activities devoted to accelerating the cycles of production and consumption.

But while the dancers at Wujiaochang and the ordinary citizens beyond City Stars might be in some sense beyond the integrated spectacle, we must acknowledge there is no evidence that they are resisting or challenging it. For that, we need to look elsewhere. First, there is the very redundancy of the screens and their contents. The sheer effort to get people to even glance at them let alone retain what is on them suggests that perhaps we are not so eager to participate in self-making through consumption as the advertisements and public service messages might suggest. Add to this the security cameras – surely there as many as there are screens? – and the suggestion is that the post-cinematic screen culture does not trust its subjects and fears they would just as happily steal as pay for the goods, or possibly vandalise them.

Finally, let us not forget Tahrir Square in Cairo, the Maidan in Kiev, Taksim Square in Istanbul, the Umbrella Movement in Hong Kong, the Sunflower Movement in Taipei, the London riots, and all the other events that have demonstrated the public



Fig. 2 The lightscape on the streets of Wujiaochang, Shanghai, 2009.

is far from being as politically disengaged as both the critics of neoliberalism fear and its proponents hope. While the post-cinematic screen culture of the streets and squares of the global city has indeed been colonised for the mundane promotion of consumption and neoliberal values, perhaps the very excessive nature of the effort is also a mark of its fragility.

NOTE

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